

Derek Wood: Senior Product Designer

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TL;DR Derek really wants to work with you.

JULY 10 2026

Why I'm applying to GoFundMe's Product Design role

While I was in high school, a friend of the family took me to Starbucks to have a chat. I'd been doing illustration and art and using computers to edit photos and make fonts. I was just trying everything and exploring.

He asked me what my plan was. I told him I might start a skateboard company or something and make t-shirts, but admitted I felt a little strange about producing something just to sell it with a brand stamped on it. People in San Diego where I grew up (and I'm sure everywhere else) would take these brands so seriously - who has what shirts / who's poor and who's rich and graphic design as a career just didn't sit well with me in that way.

He began to ask me more questions about the room we were sitting in. How did it feel? What did it sound like? Look at that logo - and that other logo. Look at the way that everything connects and varies and works within a system of typography and color and creates something bigger. There must have been 200 products in that room. They all worked together. The signs, the menu, the feel of the tables and chairs. The aprons. The way the guests felt and the way the employees felt - and the whole atmosphere was designed (for better or worse).

I didn't rush off to become a brand designer, but it gradually became a way of viewing the world. Later I would read essays by Paul Rand, Don Norman, Bruce Mau, and about the Bauhaus. I became fascinated by design systems and how brand, language, interaction, and engineering work together to communicate something larger than any individual piece. I helped define brand guidelines for voice and tone, working alongside creative directors and web developers to create consistent systems across platforms. I wrote an opinionated curriculum for a small product design school where I mentored hundreds of students through everything I'd learned, and learned just as much from them along the way. Teaching has been deeply rewarding, but I'm excited to bring everything I've learned back to building products alongside a team.

I want to be part of the team building products that help people help each other. That's why I'm applying to GoFundMe.

~ Derek Wood